Fake Mating

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/56325124.

Rating:	Explicit
Archive Warning:	No Archive Warnings Apply
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)
Relationships:	Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)
Characters:	Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Catra's Mother (She-Ra)
Additional Tags:	First Time, First Kiss, Meeting the Parents, Light Angst, Mutual Pining, Fake/Pretend Relationship, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Magicats (She-Ra), Domestic Fluff, Fluff and Smut, Angst with a Happy Ending, Mating Bites, Love Confessions, One Shot, Femslash, Family Fluff, Tooth-Rotting Fluff, Lesbian Disaster Catra (She-Ra), Useless Lesbians, Idiots in Love, They're Switches Your Honor
Language:	English
Series:	Part 16 of Catradora Smutshots
Stats:	Published: 2024-06-02 Words: 14,784 Chapters: 1/1

Fake Mating

by vagician

Summary

When Catra finds her birth parents through an ancestry app, she gets an opportunity to patch over some old wounds. Wanting to impress them and knowing it's a big staple in magicat culture, she bends the truth a bit and lets slip that she has a mate. Little did she know how one false statement could come back to haunt her.

Or: Catra meets her birth parents for the first time and ropes Adora into pretending to be her mate. You've heard of fake dating, so now get ready for fake mating.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Our dearest Catra,

Your father and I cannot express the joy it brings us that we get to finally reunite with the cub we sent off into the world so many years ago. We may not be able to get back the precious moments stolen from us both by unfortunate circumstances, but to know we finally get to see for ourselves the young woman you've become is a gift we will never dare take for granted. We've waited for so long to get a chance to meet you and your mate that fretting over waiting another week seems silly, but that's just how excited we are to see you.

All of our love,

Cynder and Milo

Catra has a staring match with her laptop before wordlessly closing the email, an orbital bombardment of emotions currently wreaking havoc on her thought process. It had her anxiety shooting straight through the roof.

Reconnecting with her birth parents through an ancestry service seemed easy enough in the beginning. It even managed to close some old wounds she'd been carrying around ever since she was old enough to be capable of registering what separation syndrome was. It turns out that after all this time, what she viewed as selfish abandonment was supposed to be deemed an act of selflessness.

Neither her father nor mother felt they were in a position to give her the life she deserved and felt the only way she could thrive was by being given to the hands of another caregiver capable of providing an environment where she could prosper.

Halfmoon had been warring with several nearby magicat clans beyond their borders right around the moment of her birth and it made the area almost inhospitable for most of the families there. She wasn't even the only kit who got sent away at birth, which makes dealing with her abandonment issues a little easier now that she knows it wasn't just *her* they were getting rid of.

Catra could see the reasoning behind it and knew her parents would have no idea just how wicked of a woman her poor excuse of a foster mom would be once the system dumped her there, but she still felt like she got the short end of the stick here.

But then again, if she had never taken on the lifetime's worth of trauma and baggage Weaver so graciously dumped onto her shoulders, she would have never met Adora - the ditzy, lovable, and *frustratingly* attractive blonde currently hanging over the back of their couch to not so subtly snoop at Catra's laptop screen-.

"I don't understand… Isn't seeing them a good thing?"

Catra snorts, promptly shutting her laptop closed. "Are you just completely skipping over the part where they think I have a *mate*?"

Adora furrows her brow behind her, putting on her *'problem solver'* face as she sits with the words. When she doesn't come up with anything of use, the determined look falls away to a frown. "Why uh.. why did you tell them you had a mate again?"

Catra *really* doesn't want to be having this conversation, and has to actively remind herself that Adora is simply trying to help pull her out of the hole she's so foolishly dug herself into. "I wanted to impress them, okay? I didn't even think they'd want to see me in person but clearly I royally screwed up on that part."

It was true though. Magicats lived a simple and solitary life much comparable to the Amish, and weren't known to stray away from their territory. They socialized with society only through necessity and trade and had no interest in any civilization beyond what's been marked by their borders.

It was less about religion and more about staying true to one's roots and respecting the land and all that jazz so while outside technology wasn't exactly prohibited, it was typically scarce amongst the families there.

So when Catra made the presumption that her parents wouldn't want a face to face reunion and included a little fib about her acquiring herself a mate so they'd approve of her more, she

didn't think it would come back to bite her in the ass so drastically.

Magicats were big on finding a suitable mate for their offspring to preserve the bloodline and ensure it continues on, and after multiple months of her mother fretting over her unmated status in-between emails, Catra finally told her she found one just so she wouldn't have to hear it anymore.

In *hindsight*? Probably not the wisest move.

How was she supposed to inform them that the elusive mate she's been brushing over in her emails doesn't actually exist? She hasn't even met her parents yet and *already* she's disappointing them. She can absently hear Weaver hissing into her ear that she'll never be good enough.

Not for them. Not for Adora. Not for *anyone*. Her ears droop a bit when Adora places a hand on her shoulder, leaning partway over the back of the couch to try and take in the face Catra's deliberately trying to hide from her. It was meant to be comforting but it just has the opposite effect.

"Maybe I can just hire an escort or something. They cater to sob stories like that, right?" Catra tries to make a joke but it doesn't really land for Adora, taking her statement quite literally as the hand on her shoulder freezes. When Catra turns to peek at her, Adora looks visibly panicked.

"Y-You *can't*!" she blurts out, immediately finding the floor far more interesting to look at when Catra throws her a questioning glance. "I-I mean it's just uh, way outside of your budget, isn't it?"

Catra *hates* that Adora's right, but she's probably right. She's never had any experience with escorts herself, but DT was in the business and if they charged like DT was charging, she'd easily be losing several hundred bucks an hour. Wait a minute. Now that she thinks about it, that gives her an idea.

"Maybe I can get DT to take some pity on me and give me a friend discount or at the very least a financing plan. They might run me into the ground with interest fees, but it's better than no mate at all." she reasons, pulling out her phone to prepare and send what had to be the world's most humiliating text. She's unaware of Adora's anxious pacing behind the couch, nor the torn look in her expression as she clenches her hands into empty fists at her sides.

"Catra, *wait*!"

Before Catra can even begin the text, Adora suddenly vaults over the back of the couch to snatch her phone out of her hands, the momentum having the blonde getting reacquainted with gravity as she tumbles over the cushions altogether before ungracefully face-planting right into the floor.

Startled and hissing at the sudden commotion, Catra pats down the fluffed out fur at the tail before glaring down at the groaning mess of limbs Adora's become.

"The hell is your problem, you weirdo? Give me my phone back!" Catra attempts to grab the phone Adora's loosely clutching in her hand, head still planted on the floor. She pulls herself up with a lot more coordination than Catra would expect after a fall that gnarly, quickly stuffing the device in the one place Catra wouldn't dare to go fetching for.

Her bra.

Catra's cheeks heat up against her will, glaring at the very fact that it was the annoying blonde idiot currently invoking that blush in her. Panting, Adora refills on some oxygen before finally meeting Catra's glare with blue and hoping eyes.

"I have a proposition for you." Adora cautiously starts, like she's a car dealer trying to work up some sales pitch she has yet to spring on her. Growing tired of her elusiveness, Catra gives her an animated eye roll.

"Does it involve you giving me back my phone anytime soon? Because I'm *all* for that plan." Catra grits out, holding her hand out expectantly.

Predictably, Adora *doesn't* give her back the phone.

"Just *hear* me out, okay?" Adora asks, an odd desperation to her inquiry that Catra can't really pinpoint the source for.

Sighing, the feline props her feet up on the coffee table, arms folded across her chest as she gets comfortable. "Fine, whatever. But make it quick. I only have one week to fix this nightmare so I kinda need every spare moment I can get."

Adora nods, grateful for the chance she's giving her to speak up. "So even if DT agreed to it, they hardly know enough about you for them to pull it off without your parents calling bullshit, right?"

Catra serves her a flat look, hating yet again that Adora had a point. A *frustrating* point, but a point nonetheless. "Yeah yeah, go on.."

"And you just mentioned it would likely burn a hole in your pocket by the time it’s paid off, right?"

Catra exhales in an irritable huff, her patience slowly thinning away. "Correct, considering I literally *just* said that."

Adora doesn't seem too deterred by her building hostility though, combing her fingers through the mess of fringe her own faceplant has caused her. "And last but not least, this is *Double Trouble* we're talking about here. Do you *really* think someone with literally trouble in their name is just going to play along with whatever role you're expecting to get out of them?” Adora rationally reasons before continuing.

“They're more likely to stir the pot for their own amusement and turn you into one of their pawns before they think about genuinely helping you. Bringing them to your parents is just a disaster waiting to happen."

Falling victim to her own souring mood, Catra sneers at her. "Are you actually going to provide me with a usable solution anytime soon or are you just going to pick apart every idea I come u-"

"I'll do it for free."

Catra's mouth hangs in limbo for a moment, her entire central nervous system forced to initiate a reboot. She's about to go off on her for making a joke like that, (and potentially getting her *hopes* up) but when she looks to Adora, she can't spot even an ounce of the humor she expects to see in her expression. As odd as it is, all she sees there is earnestness.

"I'm sorry, *what*?" Catra forces herself to ask once she deduces a part of Adora might actually be serious over the offer.

"Think about it! We're already best friends and roommates so we practically know everything about each other and already have a bond. And you know I volunteer with Glimmer at the old folks home so that makes me like, *really* good with older people! Plus I'd be doing it for free so it wouldn't cost you anything, *and* thanks to the elective I took in interspecies ethics in senior year, I already know a crapload about magicat culture!" Adora blurts out in an anxious rant, really trying to sell the point home to her.

There was desperation evident in her voice, like Adora was a down on her luck real estate agent trying to convince her to buy property on the bad side of town.

Catra blinks, still digesting the gravity of what Adora was implying here. She's grateful that her tail happens to be trapped between her and the couch cushion for the moment, since she's certain it's as fluffed out as the fur bristling at her nape.

As much as her inner gay wants to sing "*Yes*!" on the world's tallest mountain, she wisely keeps her excitement from showing. Adora was only offering this because she's a selfless ditz who wants to save her ass from the wrath of her parents, after all. It's not like a part of her *actually* wants to be Catra's mate.

"You're serious about this?" she asks, her voice wavering on her a bit more than she likes. Adora's face softens, but her expression remains determined as ever. "I wouldn't have offered it if I wasn't, Catra.

"You know it's going to mean we have to act like a couple, right? That means kissing, cuddling, holding hands, the *whole* shebang." Catra reminds her while silently gauging her reaction. Rather than the revulsion she fears, the question has Adora's cheeks tinting to a rosy pink.

Huh. Well, *that's* interesting.

"I know. I'm okay with it if you are." Adora offers up with no hesitation, and Catra can't shake off the feeling that Adora almost seems enthusiastic about taking on the role. Nope, Catra was *definitely* reading too much into this and totally wasn't gloriously elated over the fact that she'd finally get to experience what it's like to kiss Adora, even if it's only just for show.

Yeah, this was growing into dangerous territory, *indeed*.

She should just shut down this shit-show before it even has a chance to commence.

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To no one’s surprise, Catra ends up saying yes. She tells herself it's because Adora was relentless in wearing her down and not at the prospect of actually getting a chance at momentarily leaving the friendzone she's been miserably living in for more years than she cares to count.

No, this had nothing to do with her unrequited love for Adora and was simply a matter of fact and logic. If she wants any chance at fooling her parents into the domestic bliss she's faking for herself, then she needs someone who knows her from the inside and out. And coincidentally, the prime candidate for that position was none other than Adora.

Gods, the universe truly is cruel.

They’re on their flight to Halfmoon now, making the best out of their economy class seats with only about another ten to fifteen minutes until touchdown. She glances over to the half-assed makeup on Adora's neck that they're trying to pass as an authentic mating bite, worrying if it would be enough to fool her parents.

Well, she'd find out soon enough. Catra could tell they were getting close just by looking out of the window and seeing all the industrialized urban towns slowly turn into miles upon miles of untouched woodland. Seeing all of that nature just stirs something repressed and primal in her that makes her want to chuck off her shoes and run through the forest on all fours.

Yikes, where did *that* thought come from?

The seatbelt light above their row suddenly blinks back to life, signaling they were closer to landing than Catra had recently anticipated, unaware of her claws lightly denting the arm rest until Adora's placing her hand over the back of her own. Catra doesn't recoil or anything, but she's anxious enough that the sudden contact has her jolting for a moment.

"Hey, talk to me. What's going through your head right now?" Adora's request is as delicate as the thumb lightly grazing along her furred knuckles.

As much as she wants to duck and bail out of this gentle questioning, she knows Adora at the very least deserves some honesty from her. If she was going out of her way to remedy the monumental fuck up Catra's created out of this reunion, then Catra can fight against the doubts wanting to keep her silent.

"I'm just nervous, I guess. There's a lot of ways this can go wrong, you know?" she stares at both of their entwined hands, feeling Adora's gaze in her peripheral vision. "I mean hell, we didn't even prepare for this at all. What if it's not believable?"

"Then we *make* it believable." Adora responds with determination bordering on palpable. Catra swallows at the surefire change in expression, gripping the arm rest just a tad tighter.

"And how do you suggest we do that? I feel like they're going to see your mark and *know* it's fake. What happens if the makeup gets smudged and we're not in a position where we can fix it? Gods, this is so stupid. What am I gonna-"

"I have another proposition." Adora interjects before Catra can spiral any further, squeezing her hand a little tighter to get her attention. When she gets it, Adora follows up with a "Do you trust me?"

Catra stills a bit at the question, wondering what the hell Adora could possibly do to fix an already hopeless situation. But despite her doubts, Catra gives her a small nod.

"Good. Meet me in the lavatory in five minutes."

Catra's eyes broaden in surprise, almost expecting it to be a joke but then Adora's suddenly unbuckling her seat belt, sliding the tray of the seat in front of her back up to allow herself some room to stand.

"Wait, *what*? You're serious? What the hell are we going to do in there that we can't already do out here?" Catra questions, since she highly doubts she'll be joining the mile high club anytime soon.

"This is the part where trusting me comes into play." Adora returns, heading towards the aisle before she's turning over her shoulder to look back at her with an expectant gaze that has Catra confusedly fidgeting in her seat. "*Five* minutes, Catra."

She watches the blonde retreat towards the back of the plane, her mind running in overdrive over whatever the hell that could possibly be about. If they were just going in there to reapply Adora's make up then why did she feel the need to drag her out of sight of prying eyes?

Okay, *no*. Catra was clearly spazzing out and not reading the room correctly. She really needs to get her head screwed on straight because as of now, it was screwed on undoubtedly gay.

Shaking off her nerves, she pulls out her phone to keep track of the time. She looks at her home screen, the picture there making her feel even more miserable. Adora insisted they take a couple's selfie together and put it as their backgrounds to make their pretend relationship more believable.

Now all Catra can think about is how badly she wishes she could have everything in that picture. Something real and substantial and not just the imaginary act they were about to put on.

Moping seems to be effective in passing the time because when she looks at the clock on her phone again, it's already time for her to leave. Catra takes off her seat belt with trembling hands, tucking her phone back into her pocket before standing.

She heads down the aisle, awkwardly weaving around the flight attendant passing by before hurriedly making her way to the back of the plane. After a brief mental pep talk, Catra steps inside.

Adora moves back against the sink to give Catra enough room to shut the door behind her, nervously drumming her fingers along the edge. Catra doesn't see any makeup supplies with her, so she still has no clue why Adora would pull her back here. One thing she does note however, is the lack of makeup on her neck, indicating she washed it off.

"Why are we here, Adora? We only have fifteen minutes until this thing lands."

Adora doesn't look the least bit concerned about the short window of time, but she's notably nervous for whatever reason. She has a short staring match with the floor before she's looking up at Catra with an open expression. "That's okay. This won't take long."

Catra shifts anxiously, narrowing her eyes. "And what's *'this'* exactly?"

Adora draws in a breath. "Okay.. But hear me out before you say no, alright?"

If Adora already expects her to say no before she can even get it out, then Catra has a hunch this idea of hers is going to be on the far side of terrible. Sighing, she decides to give Adora the benefit of the doubt. "Start talking, princess."

Adora swallows and nods, seeming to collect herself for the moment. "Okay, so we can both agree the painted-on bite was never going to work, right?"

Annnd now they were back to picking apart her ideas. Lovely.

"I didn't see *you* trying to come up with anything." Catra shoots back defensively, growing more impatient by the second.

"Well, that's why we're here *now*." Adora counters, a little exasperated herself.

Catra could bicker with her more, but she's reminded they're still on a time crunch. "Alright then, Einstein. Lay it on me."

"You're going to bite me."

Catra feels a primordial heat birth so severely in her core that it threatens to boil her blood and evaporate it to vapor completely, her tail thrashing hard enough to make an audible knock every time it whacks against the wall, forcing her to grab the runaway limb just to keep it still.

What has the furred appendage flailing even harder is the fact Adora's expression is far too composed to possibly be joking with her. Catra is in no state to attempt speech right now, so she lets Adora continue on while trying to ward off her concerning heart palpitations.

"Hear me out. If you actually bit me, we'd have a way smoother chance at pulling this off. The bite will look genuine because it *is* genuine and whatever pheromones it produces will only make us want to be more affectionate with each other so we won't even need to worry

about them believing it's all an act. Mating bites aren't even permanent unless both parties exchange them so by the time we get home it'll fade and everything can go back to normal. I get to pretend I actually have a love life for once, and you get to please your parents. It's a win-win right?"

Okay, that.. wasn't a bad idea actually. In fact, it was a plan that seemed almost fool-proof. But could Catra really take having everything she's ever wanted with Adora then having to live with it being ripped away from her when all of this was over? It sounded like the dumbest decision she could make towards maintaining her emotional wellness, but it's not like she has much of a choice here. It was either this or potentially risk ruining her parents' first impression of her.

"You'd really do that for me?" she hates how small her voice comes out, but it mustn't have been a total fail by the way Adora starts smiling at her fondly as if the answer should have been obvious.

"I'd do anything for you, Catra. You're the most important person in my life. I got your back, you got mine. Remember?"

Catra unknowingly mirrors the same smile. "Yeah, I remember." she answers, suddenly pulling out her phone to check how much time they had left to work with.

Adora swallows, fighting back a blush as she curiously watches Catra's fingers drumming away at her smartphone. "So, uh.. was that a yes?"

Catra's almost grateful that veil of confidence Adora wielded earlier was beginning to dissipate because dammit, she did *not* want to be the only one a nervous and blubbering mess in this. "Yeah. You sure you're ready for this though? My fangs will need to pierce your skin to make it authentic so I can't promise that it won't hurt."

Adora's eyes absently glaze over at Catra's description, quickly collecting herself with an earnest nod. "Yeah, I'm ready. Heh.. No pain, no gain, right?" she feigns a laugh, awkwardly coughing at the end of it before her head tilts, offering up her neck to the feline.

Catra just stares, still working through processing what exactly was about to go down. How many times she's secretly dreamed up this very moment in every one of her late night bedroom fantasies, yet this felt right for all of the wrong reasons. In those fantasies, it was always with an Adora who reciprocated her feelings wholeheartedly, and not this version of Adora who was simply doing this for her out of pity.

She's not sure how she feels about it, deciding the best route was to turn off her brain altogether so she wouldn't have to feel at all. Instinct takes over as Catra braves a step forward, singling out the tender patch of skin that joined neck to shoulder before she relaxes her jaw in preparation. Adora's scent grows sweeter the closer Catra nears, practically tasting it on the edges of her lips when they finally connect to skin.

Catra gives a testing bite at first, hoping to be gentle with Adora but right at that moment a fit of turbulence rocks the plane, the force of it knocking Catra forward prematurely, causing her fangs to pierce Adora's flesh far harsher than she intended. A broken cry immediately rips it's way out of Adora's throat, but rather than push her off, Adora's hand flies to the back of Catra's mane, preserving the mating hold as endorphins start to flood them both.

She's not sure how it feels for Adora, but to *Catra*, it was ecstasy incarnated. The intoxicating taste of copper flooding her tongue should have been a major cause for concern, but the approving whimper Adora emits when her fangs press deeper awakens something feral and possessive in her.

Too lost to the moment to register her own actions, Catra pins the blonde against the edge of the sink and growls instinctively when Adora takes the opportunity to sit upon the ledge, using her legs to push the cradle of Catra's hips flush against her own.

At least Adora's little theory about the side effects of the bite had been correct because right now Catra was one hundred percent convinced Adora wanted her to rail her into next Tuesday. Well, if her excessively rutting hips were anything to go by, *anyway*.

The unmistakable scent of human arousal dances around Catra's flared nostrils, and if it weren't for the fact they were stuffed in a bathroom cruising at 30,000ft, Catra would have been more inclined to give Adora exactly what her body was asking of her in this moment.

It takes all the willpower in Etheria and then some just to pull back from the embrace, carefully withdrawing her canines while regrettably peeling Adora's deliciously toned thighs away from her waist. Adora makes a noise of complaint at the loss before the hormonal fog clears and she finally gathers enough of herself to shakily hop off of the sink before offering a halfhearted and embarrassed "Sorry.."

"Don't be. If you suddenly have the hots for me it just means your theory worked, right?" Catra teases, Adora's responding snort clearing whatever tense air had been gathering between them before they're both bursting into quiet snickering.

Adora gives Catra's shoulder a playful shove. "More like you were the one having the hots for *me*." she confidently corrects.

"Uh *huh*." Catra drawls accusingly. "Don't delude yourself there, princess. You always forget my nose is so much stronger than yours."

"What does that have to do with-" Adora pauses with widened eyes when her lagging blonde brain finally puts two and two together, hissing out a scandalized "You can *smell* that?! Even through my clothes?!"

Catra's resulting cackle has them both getting chewed out by the flight crew on their way out.

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“And here we are.” the Uber driver announces before their ride gradually rolls to a stop. Catra feels her heart thumping loud enough to rival the vehicle’s idle engine as she takes a wary glance out of the window, her brow crinkling some at the building she’s met with.

Adora squints her eyes at the oddly shaped structure, her head cocking with uncertainty. “Uhh are you sure this is the place?” she asks.

The Uber driver blows out an annoyed puff of air. “Look lady, you didn’t even give me an address to work with, you just gave me gps coordinates and this is where it’s telling me to stop.”

Catra looked onward to see what was supposed to be a house, except the entire thing almost looked like a part of the terrain itself. It was a decorated hill with just enough of an opening for someone to enter inside, with a layer of lush grass and wildflowers serving as the roof. Magicats tended to have a preference for living underground, so seeing the makeshift hut wasn't much of a surprise to her.

Braving a breath, she sniffed the air and was immediately hit with a scent that smelled eerily similar to her own. It was unmistakable to her and just further solidified that this was indeed her parents residence.

"This is the place. I can tell by their scent." she says timidly, a sudden wave of anxiety beginning to take over when reality begins to set in for her. Just beyond that door lied the two sole individuals responsible for birthing her into this world.

A part of her always felt as if this day would never come, so to be standing here in the flesh began to feel a little vexing. She barely hears the Uber driver speeding off, only somewhat snapping out of her trance when she feels a comforting hand rest itself on her shoulder.

"Still good?" Adora asks. Catra has to actively keep herself from wanting to hide against Adora's chest, instead swallowing hard as she manages to provide her a stiff nod. Whether it was her own repressed feelings she refused to acknowledge or the ongoing effect of the mating bite, having Adora near felt like it's own kind of safety blanket.

"I-I'm fine.." she lies, her uncertain tone not even enough to convince herself, let alone fool the concerned blonde beside her.

"Nice try, but I know that's a load of bull." Adora answers as Catra sinks further into herself.

Catra sighs defeatedly. "It's just.. actually being here is more daunting than I thought it would be.. I mean there's so many things that can go wrong. What if they don't even like what they see?"

Catra blinks in surprise when she feels a hand cupping her chin in a gentle grip as Adora guides her to look at her. Gradually, she lets her eyes scan her face, an involuntary chill dancing up her spine and into her heart when she senses nothing but sincerity in the blonde's gaze. "Catra, they're going to *love* you."

"You really think so?" she mumbles out, the direct eye contact and proximity of their faces having a hidden blush surface beneath the fur at her cheeks. Did Adora even realize how close she was standing to her or was she as blissfully unaware as Catra had been until now?

"I *know* so. I mean how could they not? I know my life wouldn't be even close to as full as it is now without you in it. Your parents will feel the same and realize what they've been missing once they meet you and discover how much of an amazing person you are."

Adora's words leave Catra uncharacteristically speechless, struggling to register the praise as her eyes involuntarily drop down to the lips that are still so painfully close to her own.

By the way Adora tenses and her breath turns into a labored exhale, she finally notices the proximity change too, blue eyes dropping to Catra's parted lips as the both of them get swept up into a conflicted standstill.

All Catra had to do was lean forward a tad and they'd connect and then they'd be-..

"Catra, my goodness is that you?!"

The additional voice effectively shatters the moment, both of them hastily retreating from each other. With murder in her gaze at the moment being ruined, Catra turns to deal with the intruder but the growing rage in her throat quickly sizzles out on the spot when she sees a magicat woman across the yard. There standing in the doorway with a hand above her brow line to block out the sun and get a better view was none other than her mother.

She already knew what she'd looked like through the few pictures both parties had exchanged during the beginning of their correspondence, but seeing the woman who made her in person struck a feeling that just hit different for the feline. All her hostility over the

intrusion had effectively melted away, replaced with a gentle wave of comforting familiarity she couldn't quite recognize herself.

Before Catra can even register her own emotions, Cynder crosses the yard in record speed, barely giving Adora enough time to swerve out of the way before Catra feels a pair of loving arms embracing her for a well overdue hug.

"Oh how I've missed you. I'm so sorry how this needless conflict tore apart our family, but it's so good to have you here again." Cynder rushes out in a broken sob as a contented purr rumbles in her sternum, the feline's scent mixing with her own.

"Dial it back a notch, hun. At this rate you're going to squeeze her to death before she even makes it inside." a male magicat sounds off in the distance as Catra pulls back from the embrace far enough to take in the taller magicat that had just arrived behind her mother.

Unlike Cynder's amber gaze, her father's eyes were a perfect replica of her own, his mane a bit tussled and just as unruly as hers. She could see so much of herself in the man that it was almost too much to process. She's able to breathe again when Cynder finally relents on her bone crushing hug, pulling back with an apologetic smile.

It's then that Cynder finally notices the blonde standing a few paces away, stuck between whether or not she should introduce herself or allow them a moment of privacy.

"You must be Catra's mate!" Cynder sings out, her face a mask of pure delight as Adora instantly returns her smile, a light tint of rose dusting across her pale cheeks.

Before Adora can even answer, Cynder pulls her into a hug as well, this embrace just as tight and meaningful as the one she bestowed onto Catra.

"H-Heh.. Yeah, that's me.." Adora manages to get out, common curtesy having her return the gesture as she gives the woman a friendly hug.

“Oh Catra has told us so much about you already! It’s a treat to finally meet the revered mate she’s been gushing to us about.” Cynder excitedly comments. Catra’s blush turns nuclear, quickly turning away from Adora’s questioning brow as she feigns a strained cough.

While Adora had agreed to play along as her mate, what the blonde *didn’t* know was that once their little last minute arrangement had been sealed, Catra had started describing Adora in more detail to her parents in her emails.

Adora was the only person in the world she knew like the back of her hand, so it was only natural that Catra would describe her best friend in such a way to appease her parents. A totally *normal* action that had absolutely nothing to do with the unrequited love she’s been swallowing down for god knows how many years now.

“*Did* she now? And what did she say about me?” Adora questions with a grin as Catra’s gut flutters and twists even more severely at the playful coyness etched into the blonde’s tone.

Cynder, unaware of the hidden mortification and embarrassment her daughter is currently suffering through answers with “Oh only that you were the most beautiful being she’s ever laid her eyes on and that your muscles-“

“*Annnnd* on that note, I think it’s best we head inside. Rain’s about to roll in and I’m not looking forward to getting my fur wet.” Catra’s father interrupts just in the nick of time, saving the feline from any more embarrassment.

“Oh right, of course! You two come right on in.” Cynder responds, ferrying the blonde inside of the house when Catra feels a clawed hand seat itself on her shoulder.

“I missed you, kiddo. You’ve grown so much it scares me.” Milo murmurs to her, looking as if he wanted to pull her in for a half hug but deciding to respectfully give her shoulder a squeeze instead.

“I uh.. well I want to say I missed you too but it’s hard to miss someone I’ve never really known..” Catra already regrets the wording the minute the statement is said. “Crap, sorry..

Probably not the best thing to say as far as first impressions go. I guess I just.. well I don't know you nor my mother yet. But I want to, if that counts for anything..“ she quietly finishes.

Milo chuckles warmly at her sheepishness before his hand retreats from her shoulder. Catra wouldn't admit it out loud, but she already misses the comfort the brief contact between them provided her.

“I understand completely. You don't have to explain yourself to me or your mom. I know this must be a lot to digest, but I just want you to know how grateful your mother and I are for you giving us this opportunity.” he adds as he relieves her of both suitcases, towing them inside before Catra can insist on carrying them herself.

Catra watches as her father retreats to the house, leaving her to stand in place for a brief moment of reflection. It certainly was better than she feared this reunion would go, but the emotion it's managed to stir inside her was enough to thoroughly rattle her. She sighs when she feels a single raindrop land on the ridge of her nose, looking upwards towards the sky that was now clouded enough enough to rival the state of her head.

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“Well, this is um.. different.” Catra comments with feigned optimism, tactfully stepping over an upturned tree root as she does so. They've been navigating the forest for a good while now that the rain has stopped.

Milo was several feet ahead of her while Cynder and Adora were a little ways behind her. Catra could tell Adora was inwardly struggling due to her not having the proper shoes to power through such terrain, though she did her best to not let it show.

“This is the best time of year to get a good yield of fish. Spring always has them rushing to shallower waters for their breeding grounds.” Milo explains over his shoulder as they all continue onward. Their surroundings only grew darker as the canopy of trees above them thickened, the trail they were hiking through seemingly endless as the minutes ticked on.

Venturing into the wilderness after enduring a several hour flight wasn't the type of bonding activities Catra had anticipated for this trip, but she didn't have it in her to complain. It clearly meant a lot to her parents, and that was enough reason for her. Milo soon pauses to sniff the air for a moment before he looks back at the other three, his head gesturing forward in a nod. "River should be just up ahead."

"Fishing is *great* and all, but don't we need fishing poles for that?" Catra questions her father, noting that the only set of equipment they brought with them was a bucket to store said fish and some bait.

"Magicats use their tails to fish. They rub the bait on the tip and use their tails to cast it." *Adora* of all people informs her, prompting Catra to halt her walking, turning around to give the blonde a dumbfounded look.

Cynder laughs at her daughter's bewildered expression, her tone sounding quite pleased and impressed as she seats a hand on Adora's shoulder. "That's exactly right, Adora. It almost sounds like you know more of our culture than our Catra does."

"Heh, I might have taken a class on inter species ethics and behavior. I'm no expert but I happened to pick up a thing or two." Adora sheepishly explains, a light blush painting her pale cheeks at the praise.

"I think it's wonderful that you want to know about our culture. I can see that Catra chose well when she made you her mate." Cynder returns to her, sincere and wholehearted.

It's Catra's turn to blush, the statement flustering her enough to misplace a step, her foot getting caught into one of the tree roots. She's just about to fall forward and have her face get acquainted with the ground when Adora rushes to grab her wrist, quickly pulling her back at the last minute and effectively saving her from the fall.

"Wow, usually I'm the clumsy one. You okay there, darling?" Adora asks her as she steadies a disoriented Catra back up to her feet. Catra has never been more grateful for the fine coat of fur that masks her blush from the world, her ears flattening against her mane. Her expression is well over embarrassed.

“Yeah.. Stupid root snuck up on me..” Catra answers in a disgruntled mutter. Adora dropping a bomb like that and referring to her as *darling* out of the blue was not helping her case at *all*. She knows it’s just an act to convince her parents of their mated status, but her heart rate increases regardless.

As they continue forward, she can sense Adora still smiling fondly at her in her peripheral vision, the hand on her wrist that saved her from falling now migrating lower.

Adora threads their fingers together, properly holding her hand this time. Catra does what she can to try and force down the purr that reverberates in her sternum but she fails miserably.

Adora *definitely* hears it by the quiet giggle she releases, though she doesn’t make a comment on it. Something about the hand in her own just feels so inexplicably right to Catra. She knows the uncompleted mating bite may play a factor in Adora’s sudden inclination to show affection, and that had the feline feeling emotionally torn.

She forces down the thought of wishing this whole act wasn’t an act, a large part of her yearning for their fabricated bond to be real and not cultivated with lies. It was wishful thinking at best, deciding not to think too much into it and just enjoy the affection while she could.

She uses her thumb to dust the pad of it across Adora’s knuckles, a halfhearted smile shaping her face when it causes Adora to squeeze her hand a little tighter, still walking forward but she ends up moving a little closer, causing their arms and shoulders to be flush against one another.

It was both simultaneously heaven and hell mixed into one miserable cocktail, both relieved and disappointed when her father calls out to them that they’ve arrived. Catra expects Adora to let go of her hand when they arrive at the river, but Adora keeps her grip steady, tangling their fingers together further.

“All right, I’ll go first to show you how it’s done, and if you think you’re wanting to try it out yourself I’ll walk you through it.” Milo tells her, setting down the bucket as he sifts through the various baits inside.

“No offense, but I’m not sure I’m going to be rushing in to have my tail bitten by a cesspool of fish anytime soon.” Catra answers, her reluctance towards it quite visible now.

Milo lets out a light laugh, taking no offense to his daughter’s blunt words as he begins to open one of the jars of bait. Rather than solid material you’d put on a hook, it was more of a weird looking paste. He scoops a minor dollop of it in his fingers, his tail swinging around him as he catches it with his free hand, rubbing the paste into his tail tip.

“It can feel a tad odd at first but you won’t feel any pain. These fish don’t have teeth nor is their bite force strong enough to cause discomfort. The most you’ll feel is a light pressure on your tail.” Milo assures his daughter.

Cynder takes the rest of the bait out of the bucket, setting it aside at the dock so she can ready said bucket for whatever haul of fish they were looking to catch. His tail tip now properly lathered in bait, Milo also heads to the dock.

He sits down backwards at the edge, allowing a portion of his tail to submerge into the water, the way the tip of it flicks effectively tricking the fish into thinking it was live prey. Still a little wary, Catra observes with partial interest, her hand still linked with Adora’s.

It’s not long before a slight struggle can be heard rippling at the water's surface. Milo grins victoriously before he swings his tail out of the water, casually plucking off the impressively sized fish that was still attached to the tip.

“Oh, she’s a big one too! Nice work, honey!” Cynder praises her mate, bringing the bucket over as Milo tosses it in. Adora looks adorably transfixed at the display, watching with intense interest.

“Wow that’s so cool! Almost makes me wish I had a tail..”

Milo ends up catching several more fish, the bucket almost entirely full by the time he deems it to be Catra’s turn. He looks to his daughter, holding up the bait. “Think you want to give it a shot, Catra?”

Catra *really* didn't want to give it a shot, but she could at least admit that it didn't look as scary as she imagined it would be. She takes a measured breath, trying to calm her nerves. This obviously meant a lot to her father, and a part of her wanted to share in that experience with him. "Sure, why not."

She untangles her hand from Adora's, retrieving the bait from her father. She's just about to apply the bait when Adora grabs her tail for her, holding her hand out for the bait. "Here, I'll help." She offers.

Catra's cheeks heat up against her will as she wordlessly hands over the bait. While her tail was only sensitive right at its base, having the rest of it in Adora's hand felt somewhat intimate. It was an obvious display of trust on Catra's part, knowing if anyone else had tried to take custody of her tail without her consent, they'd instantly get mauled. "Thanks.." Catra mumbles to her quietly.

She can't see Adora's lengthening smile, but she can certainly *feel* it. Adora carefully applies the bait to her tail tip, closing the lid to the jar when she's done before giving Catra a cheery "All set!"

Catra awkwardly shuffles over towards the edge of the dock, sitting where her father had been sitting moments before. She has her tail lifted just above the surface of the water, taking a moment to psych herself up. "Well, here goes nothing.."

Despite the announcement, Catra's tail stays lingering above the water as her shoulders stiffen in apprehension. Milo senses his daughter's wariness and like any caring father would, takes a seat beside her. The hand he puts on her shoulder is a silent reassurance, his company providing the moral support Catra needs to brave past her doubts.

More determined now, her tail partially submerges beneath the water's edge, bracing herself for whatever was to come. Her claws come out, digging into the dock's edge to ground herself. Cold and unpleasant, the water takes some getting used to at first but eventually she gets accustomed to the temperature.

It ends up taking longer to get a bite than it had when her father had casted his tail into the water. Just when Catra is about to deduce that the fish must not be hungry anymore, she feels a sudden pressure on her tail.

Her fur fluffs out on her, squeaking in surprise as her tail yanks itself out of the water at breakneck speed, causing the fish attached to it to fall and bounce onto the dock, flopping and flailing aimlessly. Milo quickly grabs hold of it, looking it over appraisingly with the expression of a proud father.

"That's a hell of a fish for your first catch. I'd say it's even bigger than the first one I caught."

"Amazing work! Oh I'm *so* proud of you, Catra. You have no idea how long your father and I have dreamed of giving this experience to you." Overcome with sudden emotion, Cynder wraps her arms around her daughter once she's back on her feet, sweeping her into a tight hug.

Catra can hear her mother's purr humming rhythmically against her ear, the comforting melody just further cementing how proud and happy she was in this moment. Her emotions getting the best of her, Catra can't help but hug her back, forcing down the elated tears that wanted to fall.

Cynder eventually pulls back, gifting her a smile filled to the brim with love before releasing her from the hug. Milo grabs all of their supplies, readying himself for their venture back home. "I'd say she's a natural."

Catra didn't think she could get any more overwhelmed by praise than she was already, but then her quote on quote "*mate*" decides to pull her into a hug as well.

"That was *incredible*, Catra. You made it look so easy!" Adora's strong and formidable arms encircle around the feline almost protectively, a very different nature of hug than the one she just shared with her mother. Adora tucks her head into the crook of her neck and shoulder as if she was breathing her in, just one inch shy of nuzzling into her.

The fur at Catra's nape fluffs out immediately, her own body betraying her as a loud rumbling purr blooms within her chest, instinctively hugging her back. At least with the show Adora was putting on for her parents, they wouldn't even think to question that Adora wasn't her rightful mate.

It’s a terribly bittersweet feeling holding Adora in such a way. How something that feels so good could hurt just as equally was something Catra couldn’t wrap her mind around. She wants to shut out the world around her and stay embraced like this forever, but reality sets back in when Adora inevitably pulls back, granting the flustered magicat a kiss to the cheek as she does so. That simple and unexpected gesture alone completely breaks what’s left of Catra’s brain.

Sure they’ve discussed beforehand that kissing would potentially be on the table during this trip, but talking about it verbally was a far cry from actually *experiencing* it. It easily left her dazed.

“I don’t mean to ruin the moment, but we better head back while we still have daylight on our side.” Milo calls out as he looks to the setting sun with a troubled expression, snapping Catra out of whatever cruel trance she’d been sucked into.

Catra merely nods, reaching for Adora’s hand unprompted this time as she links their fingers together. I mean, why *shouldn’t* she? Adora’s been having her fill of unprompted handholding so Catra’s looking to meet that quota too.

Adora’s face softens into something tender when her hand is taken, the fond glint in her eyes saying more than what words were capable of. Catra smiles back, lacing their fingers tightly through one another as she looks to her father with newfound confidence. “Right.. Lead the way..

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“*Mmmph*- wwhut ish tish shtuff?” Adora asks through a mouthful of food, so eager to figure out the delicacy she’s eating that she doesn’t even wait to swallow down her portion before inquiring.

In all honesty, it was a little on the uncivilized side, but it was so undoubtedly Adora that Catra couldn’t help but find the display downright adorable.

Fortunately for them both, Cynder appears more flattered with the earnest enthusiasm than she does revolted, returning to Adora a warm look of endearment.

“It’s rabbit stew. This part of the woodlands has a bit of an infestation problem so we’re never lacking in replenishing our supply.” Milo answers for his wife, appearing perplexed when Adora’s expression immediately changes to one of horrified alarm, nearly choking on the next morsel of meat that struggles to go down her throat.

“Y-You… you mean like *bunnies*?” Adora questions in pure unfiltered horror, the look on her face suggesting a part of her didn’t even want to know the answer.

“Oh boy, *here* we go..” Catra knowingly comments with visible amusement, already knowing exactly where this conversation was headed. Adora was *nothing* if not predictable.

“Hunted them down myself.” Her father proudly states almost as if he’s boasting, apparently not reading the room well enough.

Cynder at least seems to be a little more emotionally aware than her husband, mild concern evident in her expression. “Is something the matter, Adora? You’re looking awfully pale..” Cynder trails off, before her face twists with distress near close to the caliber Adora was demonstrating right now. “Are you a vegetarian? Oh *goodness*, I am so sorry! Catra never mentioned anything about it during our correspondence so I had no idea..”

“I didn’t mention it because she’s *not* a vegetarian.” Catra clarifies through a mouthful of stew, swallowing it down before she takes a sip of water to clear her palate. “She *did* however, keep a bunny as a pet for three years until she forgot to close its cage one night and it turned into coyote food.”

“Poor little Mara never stood a chance..” Adora quietly adds, politely pushing the bowl of stew away from her side of the table. “I-I’m sorry.. The stew tastes amazing, but I just can’t bring myself to finish it..”

“You don’t have to explain yourself, dear. I completely understand.” Cynder reassures her, taking the bowl away from her before it’s contents could upset her any further. “I’ll have to

check the pantry and see if I have anything else to suffice so you don't go to bed hungry."

"How about some liquor?" Milo offers out of nowhere, though all it does is earn him a half hearted glare of disapproval from his wife. "*What*? Can you think of a better way to unwind after a long flight and fishing trip? Not to mention meeting one's kin after years of separation is bound to be stressful on anyone."

"Liquor can hardly count as a sustainable meal." Cynder pointedly rebukes to her husband.

"Liquor sounds *great*, actually." Catra chimes in, eagerly jumping at the opportunity.

Milo grins slyly at his daughter, and the resemblance to herself Catra sees in that very grin is so identical to her own that she might as well have been looking in the mirror. "Atta girl." Milo quips, getting up from the table to fetch them all a bottle of his finest.

Seeing that being a voice of reason would be nothing but a lost cause, Cynder simply sighs. "Well, there's no doubt you are your father's daughter I suppose."

Milo comes back with a bottle of Halfmoonian triple distilled whiskey, and while Catra's eyes light up at the sight, Adora grimaces when she sees the alcohol percentage. "Do you have anything lighter? Or maybe a chaser by chance?"

"I have some red wine since not everyone here has a self proclaimed gut of steel. Would that be more to your liking Adora?" Cynder offers, already in the middle of grabbing a glass for herself.

"That would be *perfect*! Thank you." Adora sounds visibly relieved at the offer.

Catra snickers at the blonde seated beside her, the grin she shapes well past insufferable. "Lightweight."

Adora throws her an indignant glare, though the poorly concealed grin she shapes after it pretty much cancels it out. “I am *not*! Some of us don’t have magicat metabolisms that prevent them from getting hangovers. If I drink that, I’m going to feel like death when I wake up.”

“Fair enough, princess.” Catra concedes.

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Several shots and a few hours later, the booze begins to work its liquored magic. Everyone at the table seems loosened up and more at ease. Suddenly, sitting across from the two people that brought her into this world seems less intimidating to Catra, and she actually feels like she’s starting to enjoy herself.

Even Adora seems more giggly than usual, which Catra couldn’t help but find to be endearing. It feels like the closest Catra has ever gotten to having a functional family, even going as far as exchanging stories about all the shenanigans she and Adora had gotten into as kids.

Though she *did* make it a point to leave out all the years of abuse and torment she and Adora had lived through from being paired with the hellspawn of a foster parent that was Weaver. That was a level of trauma that would take more than one night to unpack and she didn’t want to risk her parents harboring guilt over an unfortunate situation that was out of their hands.

All that aside, Catra just wishes the feeling of contentment she’s experiencing now would last beyond when this trip would inevitably be over. Her gut twists with a pang of sadness when she thinks on it more, knowing once they were back home, the pretty little lie of their fabricated mated status would sadly just go back to being nothing but an out of reach dream.

Sure they may get to play the whole mate facade whenever her parent’s requested to see her for the occasional holiday, but those opportunities would be few and far between. And could she really live with the remorse of making Adora go through this inconvenience aga-

A hand grasping her own beneath the table pulls Catra out of her downward spiral of a thought process, looking down just as Adora dusts her thumb along the back of her knuckles. “You okay?”

“Y-Yeah..” Catra tries to downplay her sudden shift in mood, but her ears eventually betray her when they timidly flatten against her mane.

“Catra..” Adora begins, the concern laced in that single word suggesting Adora knew better than to take her words at face value. Adora knew her inside and out, so feigning indifference would be pointless at this rate.

“It’s just a lot to take in.. Being here, I mean..” Catra partially tells the truth. She figures leaning on the excuse of being overwhelmed by this reunion would be easier than admitting to Adora what she was truly feeling in her heart right now.

“It’s been a long night for everyone.. Why don’t you and Adora get some rest and decompress for the evening. We already prepared the guest room for your visit.” Milo informs the pair, his feline hearing easily overhearing the quiet discussion taking place across the table.

“I think that would be for the best.” Adora readily agrees, wanting to give Catra the out she needed. “Come on, dearie. You must be exhausted.”

Adora calling her “*dearie*” does little to help the muddled thoughts swimming around in Catra’s head, mustering a shaky nod for her in return. She didn’t trust her own voice not to waver on her right now, so nonverbal communication seemed the best route here.

In the middle of washing dishes in the kitchen, Cynder calls out to her. “You two rest easy now. And if you need anything at all, don’t hesitate to ask. This is *just* as much your home as it is ours.”

“Thanks, mom.” The words feel foreign coming out of Catra’s mouth, tasting almost bittersweet when Cynder smiles warmly at her in return. Her mom had far exceeded her

expectations as far as loving and accepting parents went and here Catra was starting their relationship built on a lie. The growing remorse left a vile taste in her mouth.

Adora helps her out of her chair, her hand still in her own even as they make the short trip down the hallway. How something that could feel so good could mentally destroy her in the same instant was something Catra was too tired to comprehend.

When the door closes behind them, they just stand there for a moment, though to Catra eons could have easily went by. She stares down at their linked hands, neither of them seeming willing to let go.

“You don’t have to keep pretending. My parents aren’t in the room anymore.” Catra tells her once the silence becomes too unbearable to cope with.

“Pretending?” Adora looks genuinely confused, cocking her head cluelessly at her like she always did whenever something didn’t immediately register for her. While neither of them had indulged in enough liquor to be considered wasted, Adora’s memory retention was poor enough even on a good day, so adding alcohol into the mix likely wasn’t doing her many favors in that department.

“You’re *still* holding my hand, dummy.” Catra elaborates further, squeezing their linked fingers for reference.

“And? Maybe I just like holding your hand, *dummy*.” Adora shoots back at her, sounding unphased by the notion.

Even with the empty ache and turmoil she feels in her chest, Catra forces out a laugh. “That’s just the bite talking.. Or the liquor.. Possibly both.”

With a sigh that’s at a decibel only she herself can hear, Catra reluctantly unlinks her fingers from Adora’s, turning away from her so she wouldn’t try to read too much into her crestfallen expression. Sitting on the edge of the queen bed, she begins the task of unlacing her boots, slowly shucking them off with her jacket.

“…And what if it wasn’t?”

Enough uncomfortable silence had elapsed since that question that Catra didn't immediately recognize what Adora was asking her, right in the middle of tossing her jacket onto the dresser. “Huh?” distractedly asks the feline, looking up at Adora with a confused brow.

Adora still hasn’t moved any further into the room since Catra let go of her hand. She stares at the floor quite timidly, fidgeting with the sleeves to her half jacket like she always did whenever she was nervous and unsure of something. “What.. What if it wasn’t either of those things talking?”

Catra freezes, the question hitting her right out of left field. It’s so unexpected that it’s enough to stun her into stilled silence, unable to keep the fleeting hope out of her expression as she jerks her head up to look at its asker. “W-What do you mean?”

Adora shyly breaks her eyes away from the floor to meet Catra’s gaze from across the room. “What if I just used both of those as excuses because I genuinely wanted to hold your hand? What if I told you I agreed to any of this because part of me wants it to be the real thing?”

Catra feels her stomach do an internal somersault while her brain follows it up with a backflip, the same ever persistent flicker of hope she’s tried so hard to squash over the years threatening to spark back to life. “What are you saying, Adora?”

Catra didn’t *mean* for the question to come out doubtful and accusatory, but Adora seems to take it that way, her gaze breaking away from Catra when it becomes too much for her to maintain eye contact. “N-Nevermind, I’m just being dumb. Forget you heard anythi-“

Catra doesn’t let her finish, shooting up out of bed to rush back over to her. If Adora was *truly* trying to say what Catra thinks she’s going to say, she’d be damned before she lets this chance slip from her grasp.

“I-It’s *not* dumb!” Catra quickly rushes out, bringing a trembling hand to her cheek to urge Adora to look at her again. “I just wanted to know if that means what I hope it means..”

When Adora braves her gaze, Catra’s same reflection of vulnerability is mirrored in those icy blues, a stray tear departing from one of them as it rolled down the blonde’s cheek. Catra doesn’t even think, instinctively brushing her thumb along Adora’s cheekbone to wipe the tear away, the gesture undeniably an intimate one as she lets her thumb linger there for longer than necessary.

Adora’s typically pale cheeks tint to a much lighter pink, exhaling the breath her lungs had unknowingly been safekeeping. “I figured it would have been obvious by now..” she mumbles quietly, as if speaking even an octave louder would risk shattering whatever revelations this moment was birthing between them.

Adora’s blush goes viral, effortlessly spreading over to Catra. It forces her to rely on her signature self-deprecating humor just to ease her frayed nerves. “You’re forgetting you’re talking to the world’s biggest moron here, *remember*?You might have to dumb it down for me, princess.”

Adora’s resulting snort is somewhere between amused and exasperated. “You *seriously* haven’t figured it out yet? Catra, I nearly had a meltdown the *second* you suggested roping DT into pretending to be your mate. Even if it was just to put on a show for your parents, the thought of you playing make believe with anyone that wasn’t me sent me into irrational panic.” Like a runaway train with a faulty brake lever, there’s *nothing* left to stop Adora’s confession once it starts rolling out of her.

“In the *entire* time we’ve known each other, have you ever seen me committing to a serious relationship? Every fleeting fling I ever managed for myself never grew into something substantial because the thought of settling down with anyone that wasn’t *you* was too much for me to bear. I'd rather have gotten on a first name basis with loneliness than live through that kind of lie.”

If there was ever a picture that had to describe true sensory overload, Catra’s face would be the living embodiment of it. Every word in her vocabulary decided to fail her all at once, unable to do anything other than openly gape at Adora in speechless disbelief.

It must have been a long enough time for Adora to misinterpret her silence into something negative because doubt begins to plague her face, gradually looking more and more insecure.

Eventually she feels the need to apologize, a notable stammer weaved into her words. “Gods, that was *way* too much to throw at you all at once, wasn’t it? I’m sorry, I didn’t mean-“

Catra doesn’t let her finish that sentence, her apology silenced prematurely when Catra springs forward without word or warning, hitting her moronic lips with a kiss powered by pure desperation. She needs to assure that Adora wouldn’t dare think to doubt herself for even a second longer.

Not anticipating it, Adora initially startles at it, staying frozen in limbo before the rest of her brain slowly catches up with her enough to finally begin reciprocating the kiss with the same matched fervor.

The pessimistic part of Catra’s thoughts try to convince her that this was just another one of the optical illusions her mind would conjure up whenever she was dreaming just to torture her, emotionally bracing herself for the grim moment she would wake up and everything before her would disappear.

But the longer it manages to go on, the more Catra begins to realize that what was in front of her was quite tangible and real. Every past dream of hers never played out for this long and the dread she anticipates over waking up never seems to arrive.

Like a steaming slow cooker, the kiss only picks up more heat to it as the seconds tick on, Catra somehow managing to pin Adora against the door somewhere along the way.

Strong and sure hands took hold of the feline’s hips for something to hold, each breathy gasp that escapes Adora’s mouth only welcoming Catra in further. When the need to part for air grows unavoidable, Catra pulls back just enough to prop her forehead against the blonde’s, looking at her with fond amusement. “I *love* you, you loaf.”

Adora looks back at her with the same devoted reverence a person of faith would look up to the heavens, as if Catra was the center of her very own universe and had hung up every

individual star in the sky for her and her *only*. It's a remarkably dumbfounded expression, as if Adora genuinely couldn't process those words being reserved for her.

"You love me?"

"*Pretty* sure I didn't stutter there, princess." Catra quips back to her, though Adora is seemingly too elated to even rise up to the jibe.

"I-I love you too.. I always have.. *Gods*, Catra. You've had me since hello."

Catra honestly doesn't know what to say to that. So she decides on saying nothing, going in to kiss Adora again because now that it was clearly on the table, she was going to get her *fill*, damnit.

It's noticeably less desperation this time around, timid and curious lips slowly sliding and gliding as they explore one another. Adora sighs contentedly into the unhurried exchange, draping her arms over the feline's shoulders to pull her impossibly closer.

Catra happily complies, pressing further into her, though her positioning has her knee wedging between Adora's thighs, eliciting a sharp gasp as Adora's hips involuntarily twitch forward for more traction.

Maybe it was the partial mating bite at work here, but Catra's core flared to life at Adora's reaction. She knew well enough to know she was in need, and like any good mate would, Catra needed to *provide*.

Though even with her inner beast currently raging within her, Catra still had enough of her wits about her to know that consent needed to be established first. Adora tries to chase her lips when Catra pulls back, needily whining at the loss when Catra's knee retreats from her sweet spot.

Catra levels Adora's gaze with her own, noting the blonde's cheeks were thoroughly flushed and her lips just as kiss-bruised as her own. It's a type of look Catra could find herself getting used to.

"C-Can I touch you? I.. I've wanted this for so long but I don't want to cross any of those boundaries if you're not ready for it too." Catra checks in, making it clear that she only wanted to go at a pace Adora would dictate.

"Catra, I've been wanting you to touch me ever since I hit *puberty*." She bluntly lays it all out on the table for her, wanting no more secrets left between them. Before Catra has time to answer, Adora dives in for another kiss now filled with intent, this one equipped with a taste of tongue and teeth just to further illustrate her point.

"And you're just *now* telling me? Fuck, we could have been doing this *ages* ago, you dummy." Catra complains when the kiss pauses enough to allow her a brief reprieve to break for air.

"Um *excuse* you, you made no effort to confess either, genius!" Adora claps back, though the fond and wanting look behind her eyes makes the accusation have very little heat behind it.

"Fine, we're *both* idiots." Catra concedes, feeling lighter than she ever has before. Unable to help herself, she goes in for yet another greedy trade of lips, though this time she allows her hands to indulge a bit. She takes custody of Adora's hips, fingers teasing at the hem of her shirt before they slip beneath, making contact with the bare skin hiding behind such fabric.

Taking the forward advance as a hint, Adora shucks her half-jacket and the shirt below it off her shoulders, tossing both to the floor to be forgotten. Her sports bra soon gets added to the pile, leaving her completely bare with no more obstructions between them. Not anticipating such a jump in pacing, Catra freezes on the spot, her full attention snapping down appraisingly to Adora's uncovered chest.

It yet again has Catra's thought process going through a mandatory reboot. Sure being roommates meant they've occasionally gotten glimpses of each other naked here and there, but those were always fleeting glances that always ended with embarrassed and muttered "*sorries*." Now the immaculate set of breasts Catra had tended to dream about more often than not were now right in front of her, finally free for the taking.

“Your turn?” Adora asks, understandably looking a pinch insecure over being the only one with her shirt off. Catra swallows down the anxious lump caught in her throat, Adora’s same insecurities washing over to herself now. The fur on her stomach happened to be far more thick in length than her arms or face, and she couldn’t help but fret over Adora’s reaction to seeing it.

Shoving those doubts aside for the sake of them both, Catra nervously takes off her shirt and the sports bra underneath it, fully baring her upper half to the blonde. Adora’s eyes enlarge in what could only be perceived as a decidedly positive reaction, unblinking eyes not even trying to hide the fact her total focus was zeroed in on her tits now.

Her hands promptly find their way to Catra’s hips, looking down at them as she does so. When she finds the tummy fluff Catra had been so worried about, she responds with delighted elation, much to Catra’s surprise and relief.

Adora sighs out approvingly, her head falling to the crook of the feline’s shoulder, hands now dragging through the dense thatch of fur at her navel. “Gods, you’re so *soft*..”

Catra scoffs annoyedly at that, returning her grip to Adora’s hips and allowing her claws to come out just enough for Adora to be made aware of their presence. It tugs a moan of surprise out of the blonde as her fingers fist through the fur at her stomach, gripping it firmly in response.

“*Nothing* about me is soft, princess.” Catra slowly turns the two of them around, walking her back into the bed as a pair. When the back of Adora’s legs greet the front of the mattress, she instantly gets the hint, scooting back onto the bed and insistently tugging Catra down with her.

“Okay, so soft is obviously a no go.. How would fluffy work inste- ..*Ah*!” Adora isn’t able to finish goading her, head falling back on the pillow in a pitched moan when Catra makes a nosedive for her chest, determined and eager lips sealing around one of her two stiffened peaks.

Catra gifts the region an unreasonable amount of attention, the coarse rasp of her tongue working well in her favor. The breast that *isn't* parked in the feline's mouth gets tended to by deft and capable fingers, tweaking the rosy bud until it's as hardened as the one her mouth was currently working on.

Predictably, it reduces Adora to a flailing mess, the bombardment of stimulation forcing her to bite down on her own fist to keep the moans wanting to rip out of her at bay. A distant part of her likely remembered the dilemma of Catra's parents still being just down the hall. Catra smirks triumphantly around the nipple caught in her mouth, her lips peeling off of it with a slow and audible *'pop'* so she can take the time to admire her own handy work.

She eventually looks up at the flushed face belonging to that perfectly ruined chest, her grin self satisfied and wide enough to show off a hint of fang. Catra relishes over the fact she's seamlessly worked Adora up to this degree with little to no effort at all. "You were saying?"

"You.. are such a *brat*.." Adora's accusation is laughed more than spoken, though she's able to collect herself some now that Catra's oral assault has temporarily ceased for the moment. Her expression sporting a challenging smirk on it now, the look Adora throws her direction is enough to have Catra's fur fluffing up all over again.

Before Catra can even begin to speculate what she might be up to, Adora swiftly pulls an uno reverse on her, twisting under her and using the built momentum to flip Catra onto her back, pinning her between herself and the mattress.

Robbed of any time to react, Catra feels a knee making a home for itself between her thighs, easily pulling a guttural groan out of her lungs. Adora's mouth connects to her neck in a flash, determined lips grazing and teasing right along her pulse point. Catra is left with no other options but to cling to her, previously idle hips now desperately trying to grind up into the knee seated against her apex.

"You know, it would be *so* easy for me to bite you right now. Complete it for good and make you mine as much as I'm yours." Adora thoughtfully muses against the ruffled fur at her neck. If Catra's leggings weren't sodden and ruined before, they definitely were after that stunt.

Catra's dominant streak seems to swiftly dissipate at her words, tumbling headfirst into submission as a hand goes to the back of Adora's head, cradling it so she can keep it pressed firmly to her neck. She has little control over the admission that follows. "I'd let you.. If you really wanted to.."

Despite Catra striving to keep her head right where it is, Adora easily pulls back against her grip to hold her gaze, all of her earlier bravado leaving her. By the wide and disbelieving look harbored in her eyes, it's apparent that Adora had only been teasing about finishing the bite for the sake of working her up.

"You'd really let me?" Adora's tone is blatantly hopeful, as if she never really expected to hear such a meaningful invitation. Struggling to forget about the knee still flush against her core, Catra collects herself enough to maintain her gaze, shyly nodding her head at her.

Touched by the revelation, when Adora bends down to connect their lips again, the action is far more softer and sentimental, more feeling than lustful intent flowing out into the exchange.

"I love you." Adora breathes out against her lips, and damn those three words were starting to become Catra's personal brand of heroin.

"Show me." Catra manages to breathe back. There was still far too much clothing hindering their lower halves, and she was hoping Adora would be able to put the pieces together and take care of it sooner rather than later.

Adora apparently gets the picture, if the darkening shimmer in her gaze was anything to go by. Departing Catra's mouth, Adora's lips delve further south, stamping a trail of open mouthed kisses in her wake. Catra was more than ready to have her chest get some proper attention but Adora bypasses it completely, kissing and nipping down the furry plane of Catra's stomach until she's nuzzling and kissing the fur at her navel, a soft and happy hum leaving her.

"Can I take these off?" Adora looks up at her with a hooded gaze, and the vantage point of seeing her between her legs and so close to flirting with her core may as well have had Catra's brain short circuiting on her.

“Fuck, *yes*.” Catra can’t get the words out fast enough, not even caring how desperate she must sound right now. Her eagerness has her prematurely lifting her hips off the bed to assist Adora and make it a quicker process.

Equally as worked up, Adora quietly curses to herself, fingers hooking into her leggings and smalls so she can tug them down as a single entity. When they’re off, Catra wastes no time with splaying her legs in open invitation, providing Adora a front row seat to the view between them.

Even through the extent of her arousal, Catra blushes at being so exposed, knowing she had to be a complete and utter mess down there, her pubic fur no doubt coated with a sizeable amount of slick. Her blush only deepens when she looks down to find Adora blatantly taking in the sight with dilated eyes, serving Catra a look that suggested she wanted to eat her like a full course meal.

“Fucking *gods*, Catra..” are the only words left in her vocabulary Adora can manage to articulate, curious hands carding through the fur of her inner thighs as she uses her grip to open Catra’s legs even further. Considering Adora hardly ever resorted to relying on profanities up until now, Catra would call that a solid win in her book.

When Adora attempts to migrate one of her hands towards her glistening core, Catra’s legs unexpectedly close to deny her access. “Nuh uh. I don’t think so. Pants off *first*, princess.”

Going way past her usual quota for profanity, Adora lets out another barely audible curse. The frantic swiftness she uses to yank her own pants off could probably qualify for a new world record. It’s undeniably uncoordinated and frantic in nature, eliciting a pleased trill out of Catra.

When they’re at long last off, Adora wastes no time seating her hands back on Catra’s knees, determinedly splaying her legs spread eagle. She groans for a second time at the offered view, blatant hunger weaved into her words. “Gods, you are perfection carved in the flesh..”

Catra blushes beneath her fur, determined and opened lips cutting off her reply as Adora kisses up the length of her thigh, gradually nearing where she’s needed most. A handful of

more kisses later and Adora finally arrives at her sodden apex, pressing a featherlight kiss right to her clit.

Catra lets loose a drawn out moan, unable to keep herself from attempting to grind up into her mouth, in desperate need of her tongue. Likely catching on, Adora's next kiss is open mouthed and filthy, her tongue emerging from her lips to greet her clit with a slow and firm swipe that catches on her hood. Unrelenting, that same tongue tugs it upward with a firm and unhurried swipe.

The slick that greets Adora's tastebuds has her burying a muffled groan against her core, Catra's desperate and eager reaction only spurring her on. Leaving her clit, Adora indulges in the rest of her, tongue delving lower to collect the heated nectar spilling from her entrance in abundance.

"Good fucking hell.." Catra mutters to herself, the task of staying quiet becoming harder and harder to maintain. When she bends forward enough to prop herself up on her elbows, the view she's hit with is as tantalizing as the pleasure Adora is giving her.

"Need to kiss you.." Catra breathily requests, reaching down to grab Adora's hair to tug her upward before she can even answer. A questionable moan rips out of Adora at her hair being pulled, suggesting she liked it more than she was letting on.

Crawling upward to her lips gives Catra the perfect opportunity to sneak a hand between Adora's thighs, letting out a rush of surprised air when she finds out Adora is even more of a dripping mess than herself.

"Nngh. *Ah*!" Adora replies with an unintelligible soup of syllables, nearly losing her balance and crumbling on top of the feline. She braces herself at the last minute, her lips finally reaching their target.

"Dirty trick.." She gasps out against Catra's lips, every letter to that sentence sounding more moaned than spoken. Catra grins victoriously into the kiss, allowing her fingers to explore her slickened lips, sweet and molten nectar collecting on her digits in excess.

“Not my fault you’re so gullible.” Catra quips back at her, her hand finally retreating from Adora’s core, only to use that same hand to grip at her hip. She uses her hold to yank Adora’s lower half against her own, hooking a leg around her so she could grind directly against her core with her own.

“*Aahh* .. Fucking *fffuck*..” Adora is reduced to mindless profanities in no time at all, redirecting her focus to grinding in earnest against the feline, their most sensitive points greeting each other in a slick and seamless glide.

Catra’s laugh is breathy and clipped, the hold on the blonde’s hip sure and firm as her own hips become an active participant in this sinful dance. “At the rate you’re going, we’re going to need to get you a swear jar, princess.”

Adora surprisingly doesn’t rise up to the taunt, too preoccupied with chasing down the same pleasure she and Catra were sharing in. Her forehead falls to the junction of the feline’s neck and shoulder, hot and labored breaths blanketing over her fur.

“C-Catra, I’m close..” Adora warns her, though Catra could already sense her building peak just by the erratic stutter of her hips. Catra feels instinct start to take over, the pheromones and endorphins compelling her to complete what she’s always yearned for in secret.

“B-Bite me?” Catra blurts out at the last minute, her free hand cradling the back of the blonde’s neck while simultaneously craning the angle of her own. She tilts it invitingly, giving Adora the room needed to work.

Adora makes a strained sound of surprise at the unexpected request, evidently feeling the need to complete what’s been left unfinished. She’s well aware of the gravity of such an action, knowing once the bite was completed the bond would become permanent and irreversible. A commitment that even marriage couldn’t rival. “A-Are you sure?”

“Yes.. *Please*, Adora..Make me yours..” Catra spills out in a chorus of words, pure desperation lacquered into her plea.

Those very words Catra utters awakens something feral in Adora, rutting her hips into her with more frantic intent. She singles out an unmarked patch of flesh on Catra's neck, claiming it for herself. Sucking an unforgiving bruise into the area, Adora eventually secures the skin between her teeth, knowing her lack of fangs would require her to bite harder. Applying a steady amount of pressure, she bites down with as much force she's capable of.

It's enough to break through the barrier of skin, the endorphins it releases into her system too much to handle as Catra tumbles over the edge of no return, meeting her peak the minute Adora's teeth sink into her.

Back angled into a sharp arch, the feline climaxes with a wordless cry, unable to keep her claws from coming out as they press and prick into Adora's hip, enough to draw out a light sheen of blood.

Adora's own cry gets buried against Catra's neck, her undoing following right after as her hips make a shaky and erratic jerk, a fresh pool of slick spilling out of her. Her entire body seizes up before eventually going completely lax, plummeting ungracefully onto the feline as she's reduced to a mess of sweat and limbs.

When Adora's wits and sense of awareness return to her, she carefully withdraws her teeth from Catra's neck, soothing the wound over with a lick before she's nuzzling into the area affectionately.

"My mate.." Adora sings out tiredly, nothing but adoration in her words as she burrows herself impossibly closer. Catra's contented purr starts back up in full force, delicately removing her claws from her hip so she can properly wrap her arms around her rightful mate.

"You're stuck with me now, I hope you know that.." Catra drawls out, the same degree of affection ringing in her words.

"Mmm. I can live with that.." Adora returns, blissed out and feeling as light as air itself.

It was a feeling of wholeness and contentment Catra couldn't help but share.

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They end up going a few more rounds, exhaustion inevitably having the pair pass out in each others arms. Waking up with Adora naked and curled up at her side was its own out of body experience for Catra, having her come to the realization that last night wasn't just a crazy fever dream after all.

When Adora eventually wakes up, they indulge in a handful of lazy morning kisses before passing time has them reluctantly splitting apart so they could start their day. If her parents overheard their bedroom shenanigans the night before, they don't seem to show it, Cynder giving her a polite and loving smile when the pair walks out to the kitchen.

She serves each of them an omelet with a side of cooked ham, this meal much more easy for Adora to eat guilt-free. Under the table, their hands connect, fingers lacing together as they enjoy their breakfast as a family. When her parents finally join them at the table, that bittersweet feeling Catra was hit with has dissipated entirely.

Adora was now hers in every sense of the word. Catra wouldn't need to rely on any facades from here on out. It's a feeling of belonging and contentment she couldn't even verbalize into words. Despite all odds, she had finally found a family and her rightful place in the world, and things would only look up from here.

End Notes

Yes, I totally stole the idea of tail fishing from when Goku did it in dbz. 😅 Sorry I haven't posted in quite some time. Few of you might know that my mom recently passed away last year and it completely uprooted my life. I had this fic sitting in my docs from even before she passed and something in me just wanted to finish it.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!